For effective interaction between the police and the public, a system of setting up beat boxes was introduced in the entire West District, which was under her charge. Each beat constable was allotted a beat box of his own to be used as his 'office', i.e., in his own area under his responsibility for the benefit of the residents of the locality who therefore did not necessarily have to come to the police station for urgent help, but instead could go to the nearest beat box to seek help from their own beat officer available for them. The beat constable became a community leader, and the distance between the public and the police was narrowed. Various petty offences could be reported to him and matters could be sorted out at the beat level itself. Not only did this system reduce pressure on the police stations but it also saved the public a considerable amount of harassment. The beat boxes themselves were set up with community sponsorship.

### Beat Box: A Popular Move

In sharp contrast to the bruised and battered image that plagues the police force in most parts of the country, the police of Delhi's populous West District have of late been consciously turning out in their Sunday best, as it were, and wooing the public in a way that, with encouragement, could become a trend-setting move in cooperative peace-keeping.

Kicking off with a widely attended oath-taking ceremony on New Year's Day in which the entire staff of the West District police swore 'to help anybody in need', this year [1981] alone more than 100 open-house public meetings have been held to encourage a dialogue with the community and to evolve effective methods of law enforcement.

The latest, and the most popular, move has been the setting up of the beat box system, a significant and wholly indigenous concept in neighbourhood policing. In less than a month, more than 100 blue and white beat boxes have mushroomed in the West District, funded entirely out of neighbourhood donations. These are manned for three hours every day by the local beat constable, bringing police assistance almost literally within yelling distance of the whole neighbourhood.

**Effective Security:** Backing this up is an intensive system of monitoring with the beat box constable being briefed and debriefed every day by the SHO [station house officer]. More significant is the sense of security that the beat boxes have brought, acting as deterrent scarecrows to prospective law-breakers. Said Harbanslal Khurana, a resident of Tilak Nagar: 'There was a great deal of goondagardi in this area before the introduction of the beat boxes. Girls were harassed and people felt very insecure. But things have improved a great deal now.'

But the most important result of this system is the policeman's debut in the civic arena, as an arbiter and peace counsellor. Of the more than 800 complaints that are processed by the beat box constables every day, several are of a nature that would draw a blank at the police station.

Community members often seek out the beat box constable to settle petty disputes between squabbling couples or neighbourhood brawlers. As constable Rameshwar Dayal of Mongolpuri resettlement area said: 'I have been sorting out all sorts of problems – husband-and-wife problems, drunkards, women squabbling at the water queues and so on. We are like a sarpanch in a village and people treat us like that.'

The beat box system seems to have paid off with a major psychological coup for the constable as well. His new-found role as a community leader, with the full backing of the neighbourhood, serves not only to motivate him but also does wonders for his sagging self-esteem.

**Clean Home:** Said Kiran Bedi, the dapper, rakish, Deputy Commissioner of Police, West